THE NIGHT TAXI

Written by

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Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

1 EXT. BREE STREET TAXI RANK - NIGHT 1

Rows of white minibus taxis under orange floodlights. Engines idle. A vendor packs away a tray of oranges.

BONGANI (50s), grey beard, flat cap, leans against a taxi with a dented front bumper. A string of plastic flowers hangs from its mirror. He counts coins into a tin.

A boy in a too-big school blazer, THABO (9), stands alone by the queue barrier. He holds a crumpled piece of paper in both hands.

BONGANI
You are waiting for somebody?

THABO
My uncle. He said nine o'clock.

Bongani checks his wristwatch. It is twenty past ten.

BONGANI
Where does your uncle stay?

Thabo holds up the paper. Bongani reads it under the floodlight.

BONGANI
Orlando East. That is my last trip, as it happens.

THABO
I don't have money for the taxi.

BONGANI
(folding the paper)
Then tonight the taxi is free. Get in the front. The front is for important people.

2 INT./EXT. BONGANI'S TAXI - MOVING - NIGHT 2

The city slides past the windows: shuttered shops, a burning drum with men warming their hands, a billboard for washing powder.

Thabo sits in the front seat, seatbelt pulled tight across his chest. On the dashboard, a small radio glows green.

RADIO PRESENTER (V.O.)
And that was the last song before midnight. Drive safely out there, Soweto.

BONGANI
What is in the bag?

Thabo hugs a plastic shopping bag on his lap.

THABO
A trophy. I came first in the spelling. My uncle didn't come to see.

BONGANI
Spell something for me. Spell "roundabout".

THABO
R, O, U, N, D, A, B, O, U, T.

BONGANI
(impressed)
Hayi. I have been driving round them for thirty years and I can't spell it.

The taxi swings around a roundabout. Thabo laughs.

3 EXT. ORLANDO EAST - STREET - NIGHT 3

A row of small matchbox houses. Most windows are dark. A dog barks somewhere.

The taxi stops outside a house with a green gate. The porch light is off.

4 INT./EXT. BONGANI'S TAXI - CONTINUOUS 4

Thabo stares at the dark house. He doesn't move.

THABO
Maybe he is sleeping.

BONGANI
Then we wake him up. That is what uncles are for.

5 EXT. HOUSE WITH THE GREEN GATE - CONTINUOUS 5

Bongani knocks on the door. Nothing. He knocks again, harder.

A light snaps on inside. The door opens on a chain. UNCLE SIZWE (30s), in a vest, squints out.

UNCLE SIZWE
It's past ten. Who is it?

Then he sees Thabo by the gate, holding the plastic bag.

UNCLE SIZWE
Thabo? Oh no. Oh, Thabo. The prize-giving was tonight?

THABO
You said nine o'clock.

Uncle Sizwe takes off the chain and comes out barefoot. He kneels in front of the boy.

UNCLE SIZWE
I fell asleep in front of the television. I am sorry. I am so sorry.

Thabo opens the bag and lifts out a small gold TROPHY.

THABO
I came first.

UNCLE SIZWE
(to Bongani)
How much do I owe you?

BONGANI
Nothing. He paid me in spelling.

Bongani tips his cap and walks back to the taxi.

6 INT./EXT. BONGANI'S TAXI - MOVING - NIGHT 6

Bongani drives alone now. He turns the radio up.

BONGANI
(to himself)
R, O, U, N, D...

He stops, frowns, and laughs at himself.

FADE OUT.